



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 13

IOWA

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Iowa's family courts and child-welfare system.

55

IOWA FAMILIES ON RECORD · 84
CHILDREN IMPACTED · 25 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED

MAY 2, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED

24 OF 99

COMPILED BY

MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

IOWA AT A GLANCE.

Across 55 Iowa families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 84 55 of 55 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$6,000 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 25 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 61.8% 41.8% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 55	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.5	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 55 of 55	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 24

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Iowa families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02 THE COST OF IOWA FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	35	\$6,000	\$35,234	\$1,233,200
Lost Wages	32	\$22,500	\$112,056	\$3,585,800
Other Court Fees	17	\$0	\$10,853	\$184,500
Therapy / Evaluations	25	\$2,500	\$7,633	\$190,820
Reunification Services	15	\$0	\$967	\$14,500
GAL Fees	19	\$0	\$3,447	\$65,500
Asset Loss ¹	27	\$20,000	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$51,000	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$20,000) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		25	2.1 yrs
Mean months lost		48	4 yrs
Total across all families		1,679	139.9 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · IOWA

Most families documenting in Iowa are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		21	38%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		10	18%
Not provided		10	18%
Case closed: within last 2 years		8	15%
Not in court but still affected		5	9%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		30	55%
Family Court Only		11	20%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		8	15%
Unknown		6	11%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		19	35%
5 – 10 years		9	16%
6 months – 1 year		9	16%
Over 10 years		5	9%
3 – 5 years		4	7%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		21	38%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		10	18%
Visitation Only		9	16%
Children in Foster Care		6	11%
Full Custody		5	9%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

Wapello		10	18%
Polk		4	7%
Benton		3	5%
Woodbury		3	5%
Marshall		3	5%
Dallas		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		17	31%
Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		8	15%
Other: (Short answer)		8	15%
Environmental/Poverty-Related (Lack of housing, utilities, etc.)		4	7%
High Conflict Divorce		3	5%

04 NAMED COURT ACTORS · IOWA

The names below are public-threshold matches from the Court Actors section of the survey. A name appears only after 5 or more independent families have named the same actor in Iowa. Reporter identities, notes, and single-family allegations are not published.

NAME	ROLE	COURT / COUNTY	FAMILIES
Cynthia Hucks	Attorney (Opposing)	Wapello	4

Public threshold rule: Stand With Meg groups names conservatively by normalized spelling, role, and state. Common titles, punctuation, casing, and middle initials are collapsed. Close misspellings are not automatically merged without admin review.

05 PARENT VOICES — IOWA

Selected voice excerpts appear here for readability. Every approved, shareable Iowa comment is printed in full in the appendix that follows.



Punished an innocent, safe parent and ripped my children away unnecessarily. They destroyed my family and career.

— HEATHER

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

The court system erased siblings from other children's life while letting the ex move in with his mom and legally kidnap the kids while other siblings wonder what happened as no contact came even though it was allowed. No evidence heard just a pay off.

— IOWA PARENT · ANONYMOUS

MORE VOICES FROM IOWA

They Stole our Lives for their financial Gain, destroyed out whole family major Trauma

— RENADA

Iowa CPS wrongfully founded me of child abuse despite a lack of credible evidence, failed to preserve or produce proof of my timely appeal submission, and has continued to uphold that finding through a procedurally flawed process. Their actions have directly contributed to [...]

— LINDSAY

Left my family ripped apart, traumatized, and motherless.

— NICOLE

Lost my son to a corrupt DHS/CPS System

— KODY

They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents

— CASSIE

Emotionally abused my children by distorting the facts of the case and withholding visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system has ripped our family apart. We are grandparents raising three grandchildren, and they took the girls for alleged alleged sexual assault. there is not that much evidence and supposedly this happened years ago and I just want a girls to come home but they won't even [...]

— RENEE

Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

— AMBER

The system has failed us and ripped us limb from limb

— JEANANE

Total devastation. Irreversible trauma and emotional damage

— ERICA

Ruined my children's quality of life. We lost precious years and time we will never gain back!

— PATRICIA

The family court process enabled my abuser to present as the victim while extensive, documented evidence of domestic violence, coercive control, community defamation, and severe trauma to me and my children went unaddressed. The result has been psychological disability, loss of [...]

— EMILLY

Alienated me from my kids for at least a decade.

— DAVID

Our family has been destroyed by DHS, Foster Care, Judicial system, Families First, 4 Oaks, it has caused so much pain & heartache. Now I have custody of my oldest granddaughter, but the youngest is still with the Bio father of my oldest granddaughter.

— MELISSA

What the attorney and mother has done to my son, by keeping his children from him and me the grandma is so uncalled for. He is such a good father to his children but the mom does not know how to co parent and follow custody orders.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



My children had week long visits prior to an order after trial I was seeking 50/50 and had just had the children for our week long visit. The mother didn't follow joint legal custody obligations and made unilateral medical, school, sport, extracurricular activities, surgeries [...]

— DEREK

Has made me question myself as a parent, and I have now developed severe depression and anxiety.

— GENESIS

They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house

— COURTNEY

They didn't just take my children—they fractured our sense of safety, turned our home into a case file, and left a family grieving each other while still alive.

— DESTINY

It was hell that still has never end. Not amount of time can be given back and it has traumatized me and my children and had an effect on my youngest child's custody. Not being allowed to see my youngest child. And not being allowed to seek safety from my ex to give guardianship [...]

— LOIS

As tore us apart all they wanna do is bridge orders for my kids playing games with me not ratification at all it's a game to them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I went from being the primary, daily presence in my children's lives to being reduced to visitation through a process that was opaque, procedurally unfair, and impossible to challenge. Now I have court-ordered parenting time that is intentionally withheld for months at a time [...]

— NATE

DHS refused to encourage reunification. Put my daughter in teachers home instead of family. My daughter has been manipulated against me. I can't concentrate at work, depression, PTSD, anxiety. This has destroyed our family!!

— MICHELLE

It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

— EMILY AND IAN

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



Family fraud court has annihilated my family, my financial security, my physical, mental and even my dental health. Family court has triggered my C-PTSD so badly that I am unable to work, unable to trust others, unable to be happy, unable to relate to anyone that is not mourning [...]

— JODI

Tore my family apart, hard to get a job,

— RONDA

The courts today care more about protecting workers right, than that of parents. Children are not just a bonus check there our future, why would we want to ruin there childhood with lies and coaching.

— PAULA

They took a family who loved each other and tore them apart.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Family court's six-year custody battle has ignored evidence, alienated your son, and cost your family milestones

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

HHS removed my son without a hearing based on his grandmother's lies on an affidavit without even speaking to me.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Cynthia completely destroyed my son's up bringing along with both of our mental health and he will carry that for the rest of his life. My son and I both have PTSD stemming from this, it is all documented.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My oldest daughter has now been hospitalized in a pysch ward due to her step mom as of january this year I had hearing in feb and proved abuse in the home but the courts said they did no wrong my youngest child stated this last week she wanted to kill herself at her dad's cause [...]

— AMBER

It has ruined my life

— HEATHER

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED

Caused severe P.T.S.D. as well as put a major damper on my personal relationship with my daughters as well as my current relationship & my social life due to D.H.H.S. coming to my home weekly.

— BRIAN

Left out an older child by friends of the court and let exes mom get guardianship where ex lived... because money matters more than safety when everyone in the circle knows each others secrets"

— AMBER

Torn out whole family apart

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

38 Iowa parents submitted approved, shareable comments. 38 selected excerpts appear here; the full comments begin on the next page.

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS — IOWA

The comments below are the full approved, publicly shareable survey comments from Iowa families. Data-only and do-not-share submissions are excluded from this public appendix.

Punished an innocent, safe parent and ripped my children away unnecessarily. They destroyed my family and career.

— HEATHER

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They Stole our Lives for their financial Gain, destroyed our whole family major Trauma

— RENADA

Iowa CPS wrongfully founded me of child abuse despite a lack of credible evidence, failed to preserve or produce proof of my timely appeal submission, and has continued to uphold that finding through a procedurally flawed process. Their actions have directly contributed to prolonged separation from my children and ongoing harm to my parental rights.

— LINDSAY

Left my family ripped apart, traumatized, and motherless.

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Lost my son to a corrupt DHS/CPS System

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They have tore our family apart lied on us manipulated us ripped grandkids away from loving grandparents

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06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Emotionally abused my children by distorting the facts of the case and withholding visitation

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

This system has ripped our family apart. We are grandparents raising three grandchildren, and they took the girls for alleged sexual assault. there is not that much evidence and supposedly this happened years ago and I just want a girls to come home but they won't even let me see him has been six months. I have no contact order and through DHS sent Christmas presents and got thrown in jail and had to pay \$8800 to get out +4000 for breaking restraining order or no contact order.

— RENEE

Destroyed it. Destroyed our mental health, our stability, our trust in the system

— AMBER

The system has failed us and ripped us limb from limb

— JEANANE

Total devastation. Irreversible trauma and emotional damage

— ERICA

Ruined my children's quality of life. We lost precious years and time we will never gain back!

— PATRICIA

The family court process enabled my abuser to present as the victim while extensive, documented evidence of domestic violence, coercive control, community defamation, and severe trauma to me and my children went unaddressed. The result has been psychological disability, loss of my role as primary caregiver, separation from my family, and the destruction of my career, home, and financial stability.

— EMILLY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

Alienated me from my kids for at least a decade.

— DAVID

Our family has been destroyed by DHS, Foster Care, Judicial system, Families First, 4 Oaks, it has caused so much pain & heartache. Now I have custody of my oldest granddaughter, but the youngest is still with the Bio father of my oldest granddaughter.

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What the attorney and mother has done to my son, by keeping his children from him and me the grandma is so uncalled for. He is such a good father to his children but the mom does not know how to co parent and follow custody orders.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

My children had week long visits prior to an order after trial I was seeking 50/50 and had just had the children for our week long visit. The mother didn't follow joint legal custody obligations and made unilateral medical, school, sport, extracurricular activities, surgeries, dental, denied health care. The system allowed it. She lied continuously even on the stand in trial. Yet I was punished for my reaction and she was never addressed about her actions. Since my custody has been severed. The mother would send our older two children and keep our youngest but bring him to drop off and pickups.

— DEREK

Has made me question myself as a parent, and I have now developed severe depression and anxiety.

— GENESIS

They moved up my court date. They tried to make me quick claim my house

— COURTNEY

06 FULL PARENT COMMENTS, CONTINUED

They didn't just take my children—they fractured our sense of safety, turned our home into a case file, and left a family grieving each other while still alive.

— DESTINY

It was hell that still has never end. Not amount of time can be given back and it has traumatized me and my children and had an effect on my youngest child's custody. Not being allowed to see my youngest child. And not being allowed to seek safety from my ex to give guardian ship to my best friend now my husband.

— LOIS

As tore us apart all they wanna do is bridge orders for my kids playing games with me not ratification at all it's a game to them

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

I went from being the primary, daily presence in my children's lives to being reduced to visitation through a process that was opaque, procedurally unfair, and impossible to challenge. Now I have court-ordered parenting time that is intentionally withheld for months at a time without enforcement, emotional harm to my children and myself, legal debt, and the privilege of starting over from nothing.

— NATE

DHS refused to encourage reunification. Put my daughter in teachers home instead of family. My daughter has been manipulated against me. I can't concentrate at work, depression, PTSD, anxiety. This has destroyed our family!!

— MICHELLE

It has emotionally drained our family and our daughter who begs to come home every visit we get with her..

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— JODI

Tore my family apart, hard to get a job,

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The courts today care more about protecting workers right, than that of parents. Children are not just a bonus check there our future, why would we want to ruin there childhood with lies and coaching.

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— AMBER

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Left out an older child by friends of the court and let exes mom get guardianship where ex lived... because money matters more than saftey when everyone in the circle knows eachothers secrets"

— AMBER

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38 full approved Iowa comments are included in this appendix.

07 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Iowa report comes from Iowa respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Iowa — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 55 Iowa families reporting here are not the universe of Iowa families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – May 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte–Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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